long-term, phased strategy. A key breakthrough had come in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, when Suresh Gopi won the Thrissur seat to become Kerala's first-ever BJP MP—he later joined the Union cabinet. This milestone signalled that the party was no longer peripheral in the state's politics. Building on this momentum, it restructured the state unit, appointing former Union minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar as Kerala BJP president in March to reflect a shift toward a technocratic, urban-professional leadership. The local body elections this December will be the first testing ground after the changes. The party has fielded over 21,000 candidates across some 23,600 wards, primarily to strengthen booth-level networks and voter outreach. Party sources say they are targeting 250-300 'sure-win wards', as well as the Thrissur, Palakkad and Thiruvananthapuram corporations.

Moving over to the eastern coast, in tiny Puducherry, the BJP has been consolidating its 2021 assembly wins—it secured six seats of the total 30 (senior NDA ally, the NR Congress, won 10 seats). The 2024 general election was a setback: the BJP candidate lost the lone parliamentary seat to the Congress by 136,000-odd votes. Strategically, the party is focusing on the urban middle class, traders and Hindu caste minorities, while strengthening booth-level organisation and the youth wings. The 2026 assembly poll will be used as a test bed for incremental growth—securing urban wards, improving vote share—but the party will need to overcome deep-seated regional loyalties and significantly expand its vote base to become a serious contender.'

A NORTHEAST DILEMMA

In Assam, the BJP has been in power for over a decade; CM Himanta Biswa Sarma is also the face of the party in the Northeast now. The party has set an ambitious target of winning 103 of the 126 assembly seats in 2026 (a 20 per cent leap from 75 in 2021). The confidence comes after the NDA captured 11 of the 14 LS seats in 2024 with a 42.3 per cent share.

Sarma, party insiders say, has launched a full-scale internal restructuring—dropping under-performing MLAs, inducting younger as well as women candidates, and pushing a dual narrative of welfare delivery and demographic security. A worry for BJP-Sangh insiders, though, is the CM's growing dominance. "Sarma's assertiveness risks shifting the campaign away from governance and into sharper identity politics," a senior BJP leader from the state told INDIA TODAY.

ONWARDS TO NEW BATTLES

- **The emphatic victory in Bihar has the BJP charged up for the 'mother of all poll battles' in Bengal as well as in the southern states**
- **Modi-Shah model—tight control, focused messaging and relentless preparation—along with RSS support is near unstoppable**
- **West Bengal will test BJP's poll theories. TMC took 131 of 146 seats where Muslims have numbers**
- **In Assam, over-reliance on CM Sarma's poll acumen has not gone down well with old-timers**

WITH RAJEEV CHANDRASEKHAR, THE BJP HAS A TECHNOCRAT HEAD IN KERALA. THE LOCAL BODY POLLS WILL BE THEIR FIRST TEST

Some of the Sangh leaders active in the Northeast argue that over-reliance on Sarma's leadership, local anti-incumbency and community resentment over ticket denials could test the cohesion of the Assam unit. There's also some discomfiture within the state unit. Recently, ex-Union minister Rajen Gohain quit the party to join the regional outfit, Assam Jatiya Parishad (AJP). Sangh insiders say Gohain's exit is a result of old-timers feeling 'short-changed' after Sarma, an ex-Congressman, took control of the party. Earlier in January, the BJP had also replaced state unit chief Bhabesh Kalita with MP Dilip Saikia, but he, too, has been unable to bridge the gulf between the two camps.

On the electoral front, BJP insiders say the 2023 delimitation of assembly constituencies has significantly reshaped Assam's political map, reportedly reducing the number of Muslim-dominated seats to 22 (from an earlier total of 30). Unlike in other poll-bound states, the Election Commission is not conducting its SIR in Assam, citing the need to stabilise boundaries after the delimitation exercise. Of course, this has also kept the issue of illegal migration on the boil.

The Bihar victory afterglow has yet to peter out, but BJP sources in Delhi say the Modi-Shah duo have already moved on, and are now focused on the preparations in Bengal. The stakes are both political and symbolic. A victory in Bengal would not only puncture Mamata Banerjee's dominance but also cement the BJP's eastward expansion—from Assam and Tripura to the Bay of Bengal. For the party, it would be the final piece in the east in the national saffron jigsaw.

The geographical metaphor—Modi's allusion to the Ganga's flow eastward—is meant to denote near-term strategy. In the months ahead, this will be tested across Bengal's villages, towns and cities. The eastern state is the top prize, and this time the party will be hoping to not just contest but also claim it. ■